gods manifested themselves in different, recognisable human-like forms, such as Rama or Krishna—also had the distinct advantage of permitting the worshipper to venerate a personal god without this involving any rupture with the mainstream corpus of Hindu thought, which emphasised the impersonal formless aspect of divinity and insisted on '*neti, neti*'. The unknowable *nirguna* Brahman, after all, becomes all the more knowable when it takes human form as an *avatara*; the abstraction of Hindu philosophic thought becomes more accessible in the form of a recognisable figure. The idea of the *avatara* responded to the popular demand for devotion to personal gods, and to their recurrence in the life of the believer. As Krishna says in the Gita (4. 7–8): 'Whenever righteousness declines in the world and unrighteousness arises, I return to earth. For the deliverance of good, the destruction of evil and the re-establishment of dharma, I am reborn from time to time.'

At the same time it is remarkable how the ten avataras of Vishnu, the Dasavataras, seemingly chart the course of human evolution two millennia before Darwin, starting with Matsya (the fish), and proceeding successively through Kurma (the tortoise), Varaha (the boar), and Narasimha (the half man-half lion) to more recognisable human forms, Vamana (the dwarf) and Parasurama (who wields a great axe), then perfect men who are worshipped as divine (Sri Rama and Sri Krishna), then the Buddha (an interesting inclusion, of which more later) and finally Kalki, who is yet to be born, a brilliant youth on a white steed with a devastating sword, encircled by flames, who represents the destruction of the world as we know it.

Some speak simplistically of the holy trinity of Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva as three separate gods, but all three are in fact three sides of one complex being: aspects of the *uttama purusha*, the perfect personality. There is a God who created the gods (and the demons): Prajapati, Lord of all Creatures. There are multiple further manifestations of the divine in popular Hindu iconography: a myriad of gods and goddesses. This might well have resulted from the Vedic civilisation's absorption of the tribal and folk deities it found being worshipped in India before its advance through the country; each local manifestation of a god or a goddess was included in the all-embracing Hindu pantheon, so that as